The AI Glossary for CHROs

72 terms in plain language, and what each one means for the work.

From ***AI Will Scale Good Leadership and Bad Leadership:*** *The CHRO's Method for Redesigning Work Before AI Scales What's Broken* by Liz Corey

How to use this glossary.

1. Start with the Five Terms. They are the working set that decides workforce questions.
2. Search any term you hear in a meeting, or filter by group.
3. Read the second line first: **what it means for the work.** When someone uses a term and cannot answer that, the term was not the point.

START HERE: THE FIVE TERMS

The prediction engine
Industry term: Large language model (LLM)
It predicts. It does not know.

The assignment
Industry term: Prompt
Goal, Context, Constraints, Output.

The confident fabrication
Industry term: Hallucination
Fluent never means factual.

The grounding
Industry term: RAG
It inherits your knowledge as it stands.

The delegated worker
Industry term: AI agent
Delegated authority means workforce rules apply.

THE FULL GLOSSARY

Core AI terms

Artificial intelligence (AI)

Software that performs tasks that normally take human intelligence: reasoning, predicting, reading, and writing.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Ask which task it changes. AI is a category, not a plan.

Generative AI (GenAI)

AI that creates new content: text, images, audio, video, and code.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> It produces first drafts at near-zero cost. The cost moves to checking them.

Large language model (LLM)

An AI model trained on huge amounts of text to predict and generate language. GPT, Claude, and Gemini are examples.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> The book calls it the prediction engine. It predicts. It does not know. It has never read your company.

In the book: Ch 2: The prediction engine

GPT (generative pre-trained transformer)

OpenAI's family of language models. The name is often used loosely for any chatbot.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Treat a brand name as a vendor, not a strategy.

Machine learning (ML)

Systems that learn patterns from data instead of following only hand-written rules.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> It learns from your history, including the parts of your history you would not repeat.

Deep learning

Machine learning that uses many-layered neural networks. It powers most modern AI.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Useful to recognize. Not a decision you will make.

Neural network

A computing system loosely modeled on how brain cells pass signals.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Useful to recognize. Not a decision you will make.

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Transformer

The model design behind most modern language models. It weighs how words relate to each other across a passage.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Useful to recognize. Not a decision you will make.

Multimodal AI

AI that reads or creates more than one kind of input: text, images, audio, or video.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> It can read a scanned form or a recorded meeting. Ask who is permitted to feed it what.

Foundation model

A broadly trained model that companies adapt for many different uses.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Most enterprise tools are built on a handful of these. Your advantage is what you wrap around it.

Agents and automation

AI agent

An AI system that pursues a goal, uses tools, and takes actions with some autonomy.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> The book calls it the delegated worker. Once authority is delegated, workforce rules apply: a job description, decision boundaries, a named human owner.

In the book: Ch 2 and Ch 4: Agent Job Description

Agentic AI

AI built to plan and carry out multistep actions toward an objective.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Every action it can take needs a decision right: decides alone, recommends, or never touches.

In the book: Ch 4 and Ch 7

AI assistant (copilot)

AI that supports a person by drafting, recommending, or completing parts of a task. The person decides.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> This is Assist. AI drafts. A person checks it and owns the result.

In the book: Ch 6: Work Assignment Matrix

Autonomous AI

AI that operates with little human intervention inside defined boundaries.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Autonomy is earned, not configured. Match it to the cost of being wrong.

In the book: Ch 6

Multi-agent system

Several AI agents working together, each with its own responsibility.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Each agent needs its own job description and owner. A team of agents with no owner is not a team.

AI orchestration

Coordinating models, agents, tools, and workflows so they complete a process together.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Someone owns the handoffs. If nobody does, errors fall between agents.

In the book: Ch 10: Mixed-Team Operating Rhythm

Workflow automation

Technology that runs a predefined business process automatically.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> This is Automate: low cost if wrong, easy to check. People audit the pattern, not every instance.

In the book: Ch 6

Robotic process automation (RPA)

Software that repeats rules-based clicks and keystrokes in existing systems.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> It automates the process exactly as it is. Never automate dysfunction.

In the book: Ch 5

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Human-in-the-loop (HITL)

A person reviews or approves before the AI's output takes effect.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> This is Assist. Name who is in the loop. A loop with no named person is a rubber stamp.

In the book: Ch 6

Human-on-the-loop

The AI acts on its own while people monitor and can step in.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> This is Agent. A named owner reviews results on a rhythm.

In the book: Ch 6

Tool calling

When an AI system uses outside software to look something up or take an action.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Every tool it can call is a permission. Grant the fewest it needs.

How AI works

Prompt

The instructions and information given to an AI system.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> The book calls it the assignment. Structure every request as Goal, Context, Constraints, Output.

In the book: Ch 2: The assignment

Prompt engineering

Designing instructions and context to get better AI output.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> It is delegation. The leaders who brief people well brief AI well.

In the book: Ch 8: Six Skills

Inference

A trained model producing an answer. Each request is one inference.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Inference is what you pay for at scale. Volume drives cost.

Token

A unit of text a model reads or writes: a word, part of a word, or punctuation.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Pricing and limits are counted in tokens. Long documents cost more.

Tokenomics

The economics of AI usage: what tokens cost, how usage grows, and who pays for it.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> AI has a run rate, not a one-time price. Budget for use, not just licenses.

Context window

How much information a model can consider in one interaction.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> It forgets what does not fit. Put what matters most in the request.

Training data

The information used to teach a model its patterns.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> It shapes what the model treats as normal. It has never seen your policies.

Fine-tuning

Extra training that adapts an existing model to a specialized task or style.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Expensive to maintain. Grounding often solves the same problem for less.

Retrieval-augmented generation (RAG)

The model first retrieves passages from documents you control, then answers from them.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> The book calls it the grounding. AI then inherits your knowledge exactly as it stands.

In the book: Ch 2 and Ch 3: Knowledge Readiness Test

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Embeddings

Numbers that represent meaning, so a system can find related content.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Behind the scenes of search and grounding. Not a decision you will make.

Vector database

A database that stores embeddings and finds similar content quickly.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Where grounded knowledge often lives. Ask who can see what is in it.

Hallucination

When AI produces information that is wrong or unsupported and presents it as fact.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> The book calls it the confident fabrication. Fluent never means factual. Price every use case by its verification cost.

In the book: Ch 2: The confident fabrication

Model drift

When a model's performance changes as data or real-world conditions change.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Yesterday's acceptable error rate is not a promise. Every AI task needs a review date.

In the book: Ch 6

Strategy and the future of work

AI transformation

Changing how the organization works by building AI into strategy, operations, jobs, and culture.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Deployment is not enablement. Transformation is measured in work that changed, not tools that shipped.

In the book: Ch 1

Work redesign

Rethinking how work gets done across people, automation, and AI.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Start with the work, not the technology. Redesign before you automate.

In the book: Ch 5: Seven-Step Redesign

Human-AI collaboration

People and AI working toward the same outcome.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Collaboration needs an operating rhythm, decision rights, and one owner per outcome.

In the book: Ch 10

AI-augmented workforce

Employees whose capability and output are raised by AI.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Augmentation shows up in redesigned work. Pay for redesigned work, not for touching the software.

Digital workforce

Software bots, agents, and other systems that do work.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Put them on the work chart. Every digital worker gets a job description and a named owner.

In the book: Ch 4

AI literacy

The knowledge needed to use AI safely and well.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Literacy is the five terms, absorbed. Necessary, measurable, and not sufficient.

In the book: Ch 8

AI fluency

The practical ability to use AI in everyday work and decisions.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Capability is behavior under conditions. Test what people do, not what they can define.

In the book: Ch 8: Capability Gap Assessment

AI readiness

How prepared an organization is to adopt AI across data, people, process, and governance.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Start with knowledge readiness. AI distributes your knowledge exactly as it stands.

In the book: Ch 3

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AI maturity

How advanced an organization is at adopting, managing, and scaling AI.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Maturity is judged by owned decisions and redesigned work, not by the number of pilots.

Upskilling

Building new capability for a person's current role.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Capability is a habit HR builds. Training is an event.

In the book: Ch 8

Reskilling

Preparing people for substantially different work or roles.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> When automation takes entry-level work, replace the learning it used to provide.

Skills-based organization

An organization that makes talent decisions on capabilities, not job titles.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Tasks change first. Skills follow the tasks, so map the work before the skills.

AI ROI

The measurable financial or operational return on AI investment.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Value equals capacity freed times what you reinvest it in. Reinvestment is not a footnote.

In the book: Ch 5

Governance and risk

AI governance

The policies, ownership, and oversight for how AI is built and used.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> The matrix is a snapshot. Governance is the film.

In the book: Ch 6 and Ch 7

Responsible AI

Building and using AI with attention to safety, fairness, accountability, transparency, and human impact.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Responsibility needs a name. Put one owner on every rule that moves money or touches people.

In the book: Ch 7

AI guardrails

Technical and procedural controls that limit what AI can do.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Write them as decision rights: decides alone, recommends, never touches.

In the book: Ch 4

Explainable AI (XAI)

Methods that show how or why an AI system reached an output.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> If no one can explain a decision about a person, a person should make it.

AI bias

Systematic unfairness or skew in AI outputs or decisions.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> A screening agent that quietly favors one group does not fail. It performs. Somebody owns that.

Model evaluation (evals)

Tests that measure an AI system's quality, reliability, and safety.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Evals are the performance review. Run them on a schedule, not once.

Prompt injection

An attack that hides instructions inside content the AI reads, to make it misbehave.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> An agent that reads email or resumes can be manipulated by them. Limit what it can act on.

Shadow AI

AI tools employees use without approval or oversight.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> It means people found value you have not organized. Govern it. Do not just ban it.

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AI accountability

Clear ownership of decisions, actions, and consequences that involve AI.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Ownership is singular. When two people own a task, nobody does.

In the book: Ch 7: Decision Rights Matrix

Newer terms in executive conversations

Reasoning models

AI models built to work through multistep problems more deliberately before answering.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Better reasoning does not remove the need to check. It changes what is worth checking.

Vibe coding

Building software mostly by describing what you want to an AI coding tool.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Anyone can now build a tool. Someone still has to own it, secure it, and maintain it.

Model Context Protocol (MCP)

An open standard for connecting AI applications to outside tools and data.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Each connection is access. Same rule: if a person could not open it, their AI must not quote it.

In the book: Ch 3

Agent-to-agent (A2A)

A protocol that lets AI agents communicate and hand work to each other.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Agents handing work to agents still need a human owner at the end of the chain.

Agentic workflow

A process where AI agents complete several connected tasks toward one goal.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Map it like any workflow. Every step gets a destination, an owner, and a review date.

In the book: Ch 6

AI-native organization

A company that designs its operating model around AI, rather than adding AI to old processes.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> AI-native starts with redesigned work and clear decision rights, not more tools.

Digital twin

A digital model of a physical system, process, or asset used to monitor and simulate it.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> More common in operations than HR. Ask what decision it informs.

Artificial general intelligence (AGI)

A proposed level of AI with broad abilities matching or exceeding humans across many areas. There is no agreed test for it.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Useful context. It changes nothing about who owns the work you are redesigning this quarter.

Terms from the book

Deployment vs. enablement

Deployment gives people access to a tool. Enablement changes how the work gets done.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Ask what work has actually changed. That is the single most important distinction in the book.

In the book: Ch 1

Work taxonomy

A four-level map of the work: function, process, activity, task.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> The unit of analysis is the task, not the job.

In the book: Ch 1: Toolbox No. 1

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The four destinations

Where each task belongs: Human, Assist, Automate, or Agent.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Set by two questions: what does it cost if it is wrong, and how hard is it to check?

In the book: Ch 6: Work Assignment Matrix

Verification cost

How much time and expertise it takes a person to confirm the AI got it right.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> The value of AI on a task is the time it saves minus the time it takes to check.

In the book: Ch 2 and Ch 6

Knowledge debt

Outdated, conflicting, or unwritten knowledge that builds up over time.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> AI calls the loan. The outdated version becomes what the machine confidently tells a manager.

In the book: Ch 3

The six readiness tests

Written, Current, Singular, Findable, Owned, Permissioned.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Score your most-asked answers before AI answers them. A Permissioned failure jumps the queue.

In the book: Ch 3: Toolbox No. 3

Decision rights

What the agent decides alone, what it recommends for a human to approve, and what it must never touch.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Termination, discipline, medical information, and legal exposure stay human, permanently.

In the book: Ch 4 and Ch 7

Agent Job Description

The document every agent gets before it goes live: purpose, scope, decision rights, escalation, a named owner, and when to unplug it.

> **WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WORK**
> Do not hand an agent a prompt and call it a job description. Give it its marching orders.

In the book: Ch 4: Toolbox No. 4

Want this vocabulary built into the work? The GROWTH Execution Partner puts these terms to work in every request, review, and decision. Call for pricing. Book a conversation at onthegrow.ai

Deployment is not enablement. The vocabulary is not the goal. Command of the consequence is.

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